

African art

Some of the oldest art ever discovered was made in the vast continent of Africa. Produced for religious reasons, celebrations, initiations, harvesting and war preparation, much of it represents spirits and ancestors. For about a thousand years from c.1070 BCE, the Nubians of Kush produced monumental sculpture, while in northern Nigeria between 1000 BCE–300 CE, the Nok people created angular, elongated clay figures. The Chokwe of central Africa produced detailed carvings and sacred *chikunga* masks in the 15th century, and from the 16th to the 17th century, the Yombe in western central Africa created symbolic *nkisi nkondi* figures. In the 17th to 19th century, the Bamana, also in western central Africa, produced pottery, sculpture and wrought-iron figures, and since the late 19th century, the Kota of western central Africa have created abstracted figurines in wood and copper. *Fang* masks, made in Cameroon, Equatorial Guinea and Gabon, represent the spirits of ancestors. Expanding trade generated exchanges of ideas, and in the early 20th century, African styles had a powerful influence on European artists.



Benin bronze head, c. 19th century